

The Ad Hoc Comparative Drift

A developed methodological appraisal

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Abstract

This article revisits and expands the methodological arguments presented in *Les dérives comparatistes ad hoc* (Girard 2026). It articulates a clear set of non-negotiable criteria for comparative historical work, analyzes recurrent error types (morphological, lexical, semantic, toponymic, typological, statistical, diachronic), and proposes an operational evaluation grid for researchers. The aim is to provide a transparent, reproducible, and pragmatic framework that helps distinguish heuristic resemblances from genuinely probative comparative evidence.

Quoted sentences from the source (French):

« Les critères non négociables sont les suivants : correspondances phonologiques régulières, innovations partagées, cohérence diachronique et plausibilité géographique. »¹

« La reconstruction interne, lorsqu'elle est possible, doit précéder toute comparaison externe. »²

1 Introduction

Comparative work in historical linguistics is repeatedly tempted by quick and attractive resemblances: a short form that evokes a familiar root, an ancient place-name that seems to point to a remote etymon, or a typological similarity that appears to confirm a genealogical link. When such resemblances are not grounded in rigorous procedures, they yield fragile conclusions that are logically and methodologically unsound. Steve Girard's essay warns against these *ad hoc comparative drifts* and insists on a core of methodological requirements. This article adopts that cautious stance and develops it: it clarifies the essential criteria, illustrates the most frequent pitfalls (morphology, lexicon, semantics, toponymy, typology, statistics, diachrony), supplies an operational checklist, and offers practical recommendations for evaluation and publication. The approach privileges prior internal reconstruction and full transparency of procedures.

¹Source: Girard, *Les dérives comparatistes ad hoc* (prepublication) Girard, S. (2026). Les dérives comparatistes ad hoc : Une critique méthodologique générale, avec allusions contrôlées au domaine basque. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19712695>.

²Source: Girard, *Les dérives comparatistes ad hoc* (prepublication).

2 Methodology: principles and minimal requirements

For comparative claims to be probative, several interdependent conditions must be met. These are not optional stylistic choices but conditions of validity.

1. **Regular phonological correspondences.** A robust indicator of genetic relationship is a systematic set of correspondences between segments (or segment groups) in comparable positions. Correspondences must be demonstrated across a sufficiently large sample of items and explained by phonetic laws or regular sound changes.
2. **Shared innovations.** Innovations — novel changes not expected from a reconstructible earlier state — are strong indicators of common ancestry or intense contact. It is crucial to distinguish shared innovations from conserved traits or typological convergences.
3. **Diachronic coherence.** Any external comparison must fit a plausible historical trajectory: modern forms should be connectable to earlier states by recognized processes (reanalysis, analogy, reduction, etc.). Internal reconstruction is often a prerequisite for reliable external comparison.
4. **Areal plausibility.** Historical geography and archaeological, demographic, and historical data must render the diffusion or contact necessary to explain resemblances credible. Lack of geographic continuity or plausible contact routes weakens a genetic hypothesis.
5. **Control for borrowings and coincidences.** Lexical borrowings, morphological calques, and phonetic coincidences must be systematically considered and tested. Isolated resemblances without a network of correspondences are insufficient.

3 Developments: taxonomy of drifts and remedies

3.1 Morphological superficial comparisons

Morphology can provide powerful clues but is also a fertile ground for false positives. Monosyllabic affixes, frequent prefixes, and minimal vowel alternations are widespread formal solutions across languages. Building a genealogical hypothesis on the mere resemblance of an initial segment or a short morpheme leads to hasty generalizations.

Remedy. Require that compared morphemes fit into a coherent morphophonological system and that their evolution be explainable by regular rules. Demonstrate that morphological distribution and allomorphy patterns are compatible with a shared historical trajectory rather than typological convergence.

3.2 Isolated lexical resemblances

A single similar word between two distant languages is meaningful only if it integrates into a series of regular correspondences. Isolated lexical matches ignore the frequency of phonetic coincidences, semantic plasticity, and the possibility of borrowing.

Remedy. Build candidate cognate sets and test phonetic regularity across the set. Check semantic plausibility and the existence of intermediate forms, attested or reconstructible.

3.3 Semantic shifts and circular interpretation

Circularity arises when meaning is adjusted a posteriori to support a formal resemblance. Elementary semantic fields (e.g., “stone,” “water,” “earth,” “man,” “say,” “go”) are especially vulnerable to metaphorical shifts and metonymies.

Remedy. Document plausible semantic trajectories and favor correspondences where semantic continuity is credible or where intermediate stages can be reconstructed. Avoid ad hoc reinterpretations of meaning to force a formal match.

3.4 Toponymy, substrates and ancient strata

Place-names are often short, opaque, and subject to folk reinterpretation and successive adaptations. Linking them to hypothetical roots in distant languages without phonetic control and without accounting for local strata leads to speculative etymologies.

Remedy. Treat toponymy as a stratified corpus: establish the chronology of attestations, identify local linguistic layers, and apply sound-change rules appropriate to contexts of contact and oral transmission. Present toponymic etymologies as testable hypotheses rather than definitive proofs.

3.5 Typology versus genealogy

Typology describes recurrent structural solutions; it does not establish historical links. Confusing typology with genealogy is an epistemological error: shared traits may result from functional convergence or communicative pressures.

Remedy. Use typology to situate a language within global structural diversity, but do not present typological similarity as evidence of common origin. Genetic inferences must rest on internal, regular evidence.

3.6 Statistics and uncontrolled quantification

Poorly calibrated quantitative approaches — arbitrary percentages, unnormalized segment counts, phonetic similarity indices without a model — create an illusion of rigor. Without explicit statistical hypotheses, representative samples, and bias controls, such measures are unreliable.

Remedy. Define explicit statistical models, justify chosen thresholds, normalize counts, and run robustness tests. Quantification should complement, not replace, qualitative analysis of correspondences.

3.7 Synchronic comparisons without diachrony

Comparing synchronic states without reconstructing internal diachrony leads to error: modern forms often result from reanalysis, analogy, and morphological restructuring.

Remedy. Prioritize internal reconstruction; when impossible, make uncertainties explicit and propose alternative, testable scenarios. Evaluate areal plausibility and shared innovations together.

4 Operational checklist

Criterion	Key question
Regular phonological correspondences	Is there a systematic series of correspondences across multiple items?
Shared innovations	Are there common, unexpected changes that can be explained?
Diachronic coherence	Can modern forms be linked to plausible earlier states?
Areal plausibility	Do geography and contact history make diffusion credible?
Control for borrowings	Can forms be better explained by borrowing than inheritance?
Typological assessment	Is the similarity a frequent typological solution rather than inheritance?
Reproducible statistics	Are quantitative measures accompanied by model, sample, and tests?

5 Critical discussion and practical recommendations

Comparative practice sometimes suffers from a lack of methodological transparency: incomplete correspondence series, absence of intermediate forms, and omission of alternative explanations (borrowing, convergence). To raise the quality of proposals, the following measures are recommended:

- 1. Data transparency.** Publish full lists of compared items, attested forms, proposed reconstructions, and the phonetic rules invoked. Correspondence tables must be readable and reproducible.
- 2. Competing scenarios.** For each proposed link, present alternative scenarios (borrowing, typological convergence, substrate) and explain why they are accepted or rejected.
- 3. Robustness testing.** Apply sensitivity analyses: remove items, vary phonetic assumptions, and check the stability of conclusions.
- 4. Interdisciplinary integration.** When relevant, incorporate archaeological, historical, and genetic data to assess areal and chronological plausibility.
- 5. Interpretive modesty.** In poorly documented domains, adopt a cautious stance: present hypotheses as testable proposals rather than certainties.

6 Conclusion

Ad hoc comparative drifts are not merely isolated mistakes; they often reflect a structural methodological deficit that conflates resemblance with proof. Reinstating the non-negotiable

principles — regular phonological correspondences, shared innovations, diachronic coherence, areal plausibility, and prior internal reconstruction — restores the conditions for rigorous comparative work. Methodological vigilance is not an obstacle to discovery but its prerequisite.

Notes

1. Girard, S. (2026). *Les dérives comparatistes ad hoc : Une critique méthodologique générale, avec allusions contrôlées au domaine basque*. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19712695>.
2. For further methodological background, see Campbell (2013), Hock & Joseph (2009), and Ringe & Eska (2013).

References

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- [8] Girard, S. *Les dérives comparatistes ad hoc: Une critique méthodologique générale, avec allusions contrôlées au domaine basque* (<https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19712695>)